forwarded them to Daud Khan, a wordless intimation of the fate that awaited him, if he persisted in his resistance.

Munim Khan invited the Padshah to come to Patna and organized a noisome reception, designed to intimidate the enemy. Akbar sent a fleet of boats bearing cannons and gunners and ‘the noise, the smoke and the concussion shook the earth and the neighbourhood… became dark… The horrific noise wound its way into the brains of the darkened foe and their gall-bladders became water.’ Daud Khan almost immediately sued for peace but this was an option that Akbar was well placed to refuse. He offered, instead, to fight Daud Khan in single combat, with arms of his choice. He also offered to send a strong warrior against a chosen man of Daud Khan’s and, as a last resort, suggested that they could send an elephant from each side to fight the other. But perhaps sensing that he was in the presence of an unstoppable force of nature, Daud Khan demurred and chose to flee.

Once again, Akbar had performed the unthinkable. He had brought an enormous army, with elephants and horsemen and cannons and gunpowder, by river through the worst of the monsoon storms right across the empire. He had planned his march with meticulous precision, controlling the movements and the lives of thousands of men and animals, on land and on the water, in the scouring rain, with seamless power. Patna was taken without a fight and enormous treasure fell to the Mughal army. ‘Though he had 20,000 horsemen and fierce war elephants without number,’ wrote a sneering Badauni, present among the troops on land, ‘[Daud] fled shaking with terror.’ Indeed, Daud Khan was believed to have possessed an enormous army of 40,000 cavalry, an infantry of 1,50,000, thousands of elephants and guns, in addition to a respectable number of war boats.

Bihar was described admiringly by Abu’l Fazl as a province in which ‘agriculture flourishes in a high degree.’ Rice, especially, was of the highest quality and quantity, while there was also sugarcane, an important cash crop. Paper was produced, precious stones from foreign shores were traded, gilded glass was manufactured and there were also some more whimsical specialities—parrots were in abundance as well as Barbary goats, who were fattened to such an extent that they had to be carried around on litters.

Akbar now assembled a large army at Patna and entrusted its command to Munim Khan who was appointed Governor, while Raja Todar Mal and Ram Das Kachhwaha were appointed diwan and naib diwan, with instructions to pursue Daud Khan and subjugate Bengal. On the road back